

St. Dominic Church Wedding Guidelines

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“And I will betroth you to me forever. I will betroth you to me in righteousness and in justice, in steadfast love, and in mercy.” – Hosea 2:19

Congratulations on your engagement! Weddings are times of immense grace for brides and grooms and for their families, friends, and the entire parish community. The priests and staff at St. Dominic Catholic Church rejoice in your engagement and are glad to help you prepare for the lifelong union you will create on your wedding day.

In this document, you will find a list of parish policies and procedures to assist you with both the St. Dominic Church Marriage Preparation Program and your planning of the wedding celebration itself. These policies are meant to ensure that your preparation for marriage is thorough and that your celebration of marriage is beautiful.

Arranging Your Wedding

All parishioners who wish to have their wedding at St. Dominic are most welcome. We will also consider requests from those with some personal or family connection to the parish.

St. Dominic Church is part of the Diocese of Youngstown, which requires that couples notify the parish **at least six months** before their planned date. Please call the parish office and ask to speak with the priest to begin making arrangements. The date for the wedding can be confirmed only *after* the couple has met with the priest for the pre-nuptial interview. We therefore do not advise that you begin reserving a reception hall, photographer, etc., until after your first meeting with the priest.

Date and Time of the Celebration

Weddings may take place on almost any day of the year, save for Good Friday and Holy Saturday. If the wedding is to be celebrated during Advent or Lent, we ask the couple to keep in mind the special character of these liturgical seasons.

Weddings are celebrated at either 3 p.m. or 6 p.m. on Fridays and 2 p.m. on Saturdays. We ask that the wedding party, florist, photographer, videographer, et al. arrive one hour prior to the wedding time and vacate the premises an hour and a half after the start time. If after having scheduled your wedding you must cancel or change the date and/or time, please contact the priest immediately.

Cost

Inspired by the scriptural principle of tithing the first portion to God, couples may consider a gift of 10% of the cost of their wedding expenses as an offering to the Lord. In this spirit, St. Dominic Church requests a minimal offering of:

\$500 for registered parishioners

\$700.00 for non-parishioners

The offering to the church should be paid in full to “St. Dominic Church” at least one month before the wedding takes place. This check can be given or sent to the priest overseeing your wedding preparations or dropped off at the parish office during regular hours. Please note that no active parishioner will be denied a wedding if the full requested offering cannot be met.

The Director of Music is paid a required \$200, even if you are planning to reserve a guest musician to play. Please arrange your wedding music selections and payment directly with the parish music director. The priest will provide you with contact information for the music director. Payment of musicians must be completed before the start of the wedding rehearsal.

If you would like, altar servers can be arranged to serve at your wedding. The suggested stipend is \$25 per server, paid directly to each server.

Small Weddings

There are occasions when a couple would be well-advised to have a simple wedding ceremony—for example, if the couple is elderly; when it is a second marriage for either party; or when the couple is cohabiting. There need not be music at small weddings, though this remains possible to arrange.

Preparing for Marriage

“Preparation for marriage is of prime importance.” – *Catechism* §1632

The priest will lead and encourage you through the various steps of marriage preparation.

Regular Prayer and Practice of the Catholic Faith

The purpose of Catholic marriage is to draw near to God in and through family life. Because the bride and groom are the ones who both make and live this reality, the primary responsibility for marriage preparation falls upon the couple itself. In their preparation for marriage, couples are expected to pray every day, to attend Mass every Sunday and Holy Day of Obligation, to make regular use of the Sacrament of Confession, and to commit to living in the state of grace.

Instruction

Marriage preparation also entails a series of instructional meetings. The purpose of these meetings is to help the couple come to know and love the truth about Christian marriage so that

the couple can honestly and enthusiastically live the responsibilities and joys of married life. Of primary importance in this instruction are the permanence of marriage and the sacred character of human sexuality. This instruction will also promote your readiness to welcome and educate the children born of your union.

At St. Dominic Church, the Marriage Preparation Program normally consists of 5 meetings with a priest, 1 online webinar on Natural Family Planning, at least 1 meeting with a mentor couple in the parish to discuss the practical aspects of Natural Family Planning and parenting, and the completion of a pre-marital inventory questionnaire through FOCCUS (Facilitating Open Couple Communication, Understanding & Study). The following is a typical outline of the meeting sequences:

Meeting #1: Introduction to Marriage and Prenuptial Interview

Meeting #2: The Theology of Marriage

Natural Family Planning Webinar

Meeting #3: Procreating and Rearing Children

Meeting with Mentor Couple

Meeting #4: FOCCUS Inventory Discussion

Meeting #5: FOCCUS Follow-Up + Planning and Preparing for the Wedding Ceremony

Required Documents

Completion of the Pre-Marital Investigation Form:

In the couple's first meeting with the priest, the priest will ask each party to answer under oath a series of formal questions designed to establish that the couple is free to marry in the Church, that the man and woman have a correct understanding of the responsibilities of Christian marriage, and that they have the intentions and the ability to fulfill their marriage vows. At the conclusion of the investigation, both parties will sign the form.

Baptismal Certificate (dated within six months of the wedding):

To obtain this, contact the church of your baptism within six months of your wedding and ask the church to send a dated and sealed certificate to St. Dominic Church, addressed to the priest preparing you for marriage. If you are a Catholic, this certificate should also indicate when you received First Holy Communion and Confirmation. If it does not, additional documentation will be necessary, especially regarding your Confirmation.

Civil Marriage License:

A civil marriage license is valid for 60 days from the date of issue. It is recommended that the license be obtained about three weeks before the wedding date, just in case unforeseen

circumstances cause the ceremony to be postponed. The couple must bring the license to the wedding rehearsal, and the priest will return the signed license to the civil authorities after the ceremony. Please note that a priest or deacon cannot legally officiate at your wedding without your obtaining a wedding license. No license, no wedding—no exceptions.

If neither party is a parishioner of St. Dominic Church:

Permission to marry outside your parish is required if neither of you is a member of St. Dominic Church. In such a case, only one letter is required from one of your pastors (if only one party is Catholic, the letter comes from the Catholic party's pastor).

For those who have been previously married:

If either party, regardless of religious affiliation, has been previously married, he or she will need either a death certificate (if the previous spouse has died) or an ecclesiastical decree of nullity (in the case of divorce where the spouse is still living). Copies of these documents, as well as the civil wedding certificate and, in the case of divorce, decree of dissolution/divorce, should be given to the priest.

For couples where one party is not Catholic:

If you are a Catholic who is engaged to a baptized non-Catholic (or a non-Christian), you will have to petition for permission (or a dispensation) to marry. This process is easily completed through the priest who is preparing you for marriage. The permission (or dispensation) is given on the condition that the Catholic party promises to do all he or she can to remain an active Catholic and to raise as Catholics any children born of your union.

Rehearsal

The rehearsal should be scheduled at the same time the wedding date is set, typically after the first meeting with the priest. Rehearsals are usually held the evening before the wedding. Rehearsals go smoothly when they begin on time and are attended only by those directly involved in the ceremony. Too large a group often leads to confusion. Since a good portion of the rehearsal is spent organizing the bridal procession, the bride should work out beforehand the order of procession. At the rehearsal, couples must remit payment of all outstanding fees. They should also bring their civil marriage license (with its envelope) and give it to the priest.

Wedding Ceremony

As the date of your wedding approaches, the priest will discuss with you the specifics of the ceremony, which is typically discussed in the final marriage preparation meeting.

The Kind of Ceremony

The most significant decision that you will make in this regard is whether to have a Nuptial Mass or a simple ceremony. When both parties are Catholic, the Mass is recommended, since you can then solemnize your union in and through the Sacrifice of the Mass and the reception of Holy Communion. At ecumenical or interfaith weddings, on the other hand, a Wedding Ceremony is

ordinarily celebrated. The priest will be able to advise you as to the most appropriate option for your circumstances.

Regardless of the type of ceremony, you will have the opportunity to choose the readings from a selection of scripture readings, as well as the reader(s) who will proclaim the sacred texts intelligently and appropriately.

Music, Flowers, Timing, Photography, etc.

All music chosen for your wedding must be sacred music, suitable for Catholic worship, and require final approval by the music director and the pastor. No recorded music may be used in the church. All instrumentalists and cantors are to play/sing from the choir loft.

The use of “unity candles” is not permitted at the church. If desired, unity candles belong best at the wedding reception, where they can be incorporated into the first dinner blessing of the newly married couple.

Floral decorations must be tasteful and may may never obscure the pulpit or altars. The priest will discuss with you where flowers can be arranged. Use of pew decorations is permissible, but tape or staples may not be used. Candles in the body of the church must be enclosed in glass globes so as not to drip wax and must be attached to the pews in such a way that no scratch marks are left. Decorations must be removed immediately after the wedding either by the florist or the family, or they will be discarded. Runners are not permitted.

Please make every effort to be on time for both the rehearsal and the wedding. Excessive delays always create tension, and, if the day’s schedule of services is tight, they may even necessitate the shortening of your ceremony. The priest reserves the right to change your ceremony on the spot from a Nuptial Mass to a Wedding Ceremony if the wedding party arrives too late.

The bridal party will meet in the Siena Room and Parish Library on the day of the ceremony to prepare for the liturgy. The groomsmen may gather in the parish center and then prepare for the procession at the side entrance of the church, ultimately joining the groom in the sacristy.

For the duration of the ceremony, photographers must stay in the nave of the church. Under no conditions will they be allowed to enter the sanctuary. Moreover, when taking pictures, they should not use flash or interfere with the liturgy by, for example, blocking the procession or distracting the wedding party. Lighting equipment should not inhibit anyone’s view of the ceremony. As a courtesy, all photographers should check in with the officiating priest before beginning their work.

If the wedding is at 2 p.m. on Saturday, all post-ceremony photos, if desired, must be completed by 4 p.m., when Confessions begin in the church. If such cases, a receiving line is not permitted.

Dress, Decorum, and Comportment in the Church

Wedding attire should respect the sacred nature of the Sacrament of Matrimony. Modesty in dress is expected for the wedding party and all guests. Every effort should be made to prevent dresses that reveal cleavage. Accessories such as hats, sunglasses, and flipflops are not appropriate. Drinks (besides water), snacks, and gum are not permitted in the church.

No alcoholic beverages or illegal drugs are permitted on the property. If they are discovered, the wedding will be canceled immediately. A bride and groom who arrive under the influence of alcohol or drugs will not be permitted to go through with the ceremony.

Your guests should not throw anything inside or outside the church, whether rice, bird seed, confetti, fireworks, or flower petals. Flower girls may carry flowers but may not scatter them.

Exceptional Circumstances

You may wish to have a priest from outside St. Dominic Church officiate your wedding. Please discuss this with the priest from St. Dominic who is preparing you for marriage. If you wish to have a clergyperson of another denomination assist at your wedding, ask the priest from St. Dominic to discuss the possibilities.

If you are a parishioner who is planning a wedding at another parish or outside the diocese, please inform the priest at St. Dominic, and he will be glad to be of assistance. If your marriage preparation will be handled by St. Dominic Church and your paperwork prepared and sent by us through the Diocese of Youngstown to the diocese where you will be married, we ask for an offering of \$250.00 for the work involved.

The priests and parish staff of St. Dominic Church will do all we can in your marriage preparation to make your wedding celebration a joyful, sacred, and memorable beginning to a beautiful, fulfilling, and fruitful marriage. We pray that God strengthens and purifies your love and draws you closer to himself throughout your preparation for this *great sacrament* (Eph 5:32).

Sincerely in Christ,

The Dominican Fathers of St. Dominic Church

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